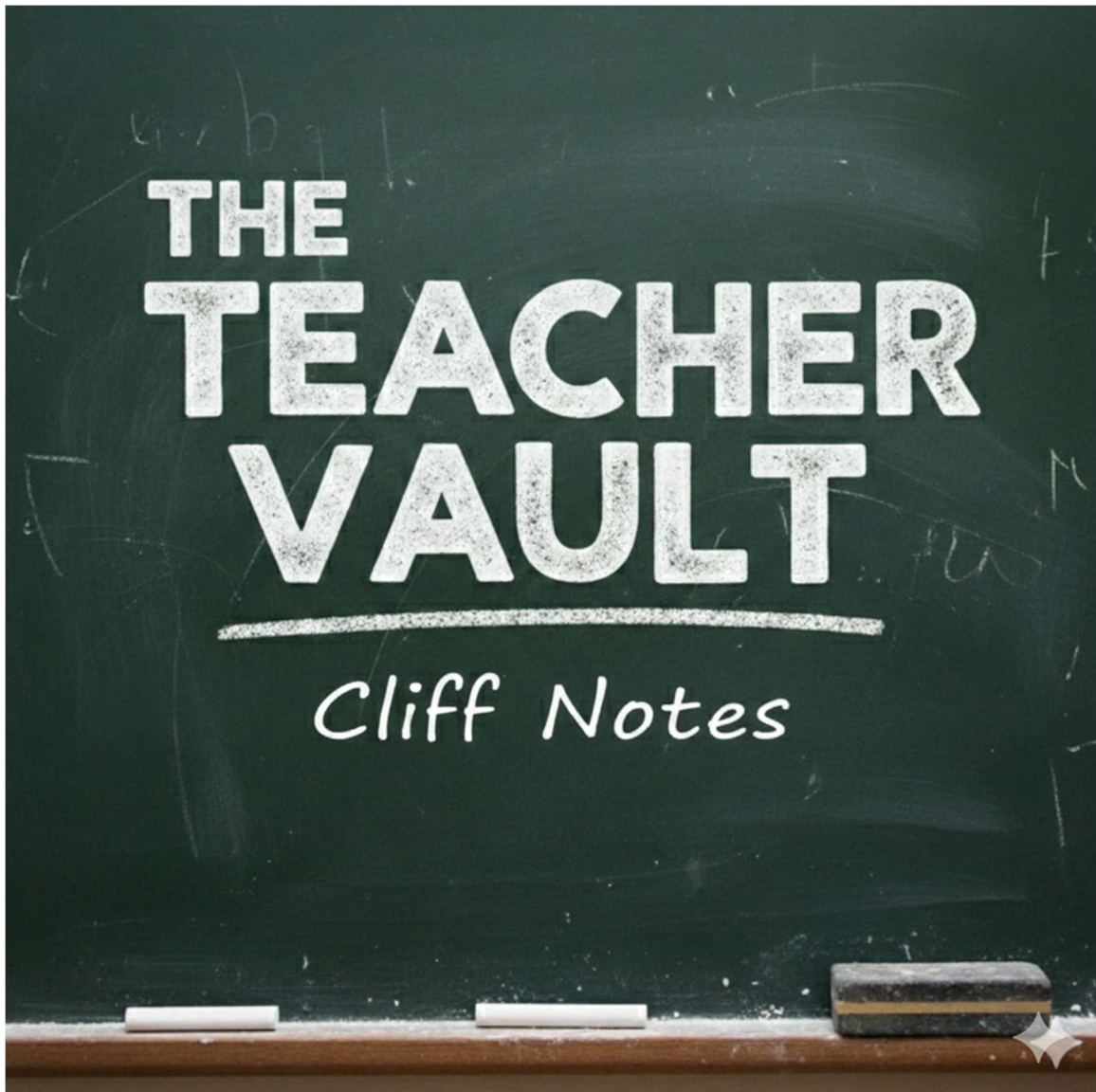


MACBETH – CLIFF NOTES

Revision Summary



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1. CONTEXT (What You Must Know)

- Written by **William Shakespeare** in 1606.
 - Written for **King James I** (who was interested in witchcraft).
 - Reflects Jacobean beliefs about:
 - The **Divine Right of Kings** (kings chosen by God).
 - The **Great Chain of Being** (natural order).
 - Supernatural forces and fate.
 - A tragedy – focuses on a tragic hero whose flaw leads to downfall.
-

2. PLOT SUMMARY (Act by Act)

Act 1 – The Spark

- Three witches predict:
 - Macbeth will become Thane of Cawdor.
 - Macbeth will become King.
 - Banquo's sons will be kings.
 - Macbeth is made Thane of Cawdor.
 - Lady Macbeth persuades him to kill King Duncan.
-

Act 2 – The Crime

- Macbeth murders King Duncan.
 - He hallucinates a dagger before the murder.
 - He kills the guards to cover his guilt.
 - Duncan's sons flee.
 - Macbeth is crowned king.
-

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Act 3 – Paranoia Begins

- Macbeth fears Banquo's prophecy.
 - He hires murderers to kill Banquo and Fleance.
 - Banquo is killed; Fleance escapes.
 - Macbeth sees Banquo's ghost at a banquet.
-

Act 4 – False Security

- Witches give three new prophecies:
 1. Beware Macduff.
 2. No man "born of woman" can harm Macbeth.
 3. Macbeth will not fall until Birnam Wood comes to Dunsinane.
 - Macbeth orders the murder of Macduff's family.
 - Macduff joins Malcolm in England.
-

Act 5 – The Downfall

- Lady Macbeth sleepwalks; guilt overwhelms her.
 - Malcolm's army uses branches from Birnam Wood.
 - Macduff reveals he was born by Caesarean section.
 - Macduff kills Macbeth.
 - Malcolm becomes king.
-

3. MAIN CHARACTERS

Macbeth

- Brave soldier.
- Ambitious.
- Easily influenced.
- Becomes a tyrant.
- Tragic hero.

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Lady Macbeth

- Manipulative.
- Ambitious.
- Challenges gender roles.
- Driven by power.
- Destroyed by guilt.

Banquo

- Loyal.
- Moral contrast to Macbeth.
- Represents integrity.

Macduff

- Loyal to Scotland.
- Avenger.
- Represents justice.

The Witches

- Symbolise fate and temptation.
- Create moral confusion.

4. KEY THEMES

Ambition

- “Vaulting ambition” leads to destruction.

Guilt

- Hallucinations.
- Blood imagery.
- Sleep disturbance.

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The Supernatural

- Witches.
- Ghosts.
- Visions.

Appearance vs Reality

- “Look like the innocent flower...”
- Deception throughout.

Power and Corruption

- Absolute power corrupts Macbeth.
-

5. KEY QUOTES (High Impact for Exams)

- “Fair is foul, and foul is fair.”
 - “Vaulting ambition.”
 - “Is this a dagger which I see before me?”
 - “Out, damned spot!”
 - “Life’s but a walking shadow.”
-

6. STRUCTURE

- Five acts.
 - Follows tragic structure:
 - Exposition
 - Rising action
 - Climax (Banquet scene)
 - Falling action
 - Catastrophe (Macbeth’s death)
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7. EXAM TIPS (Head of Year Advice)

- Always link to:
 - Context (King James, witchcraft, Divine Right).
 - Shakespeare's message.
 - Use short embedded quotes.
 - Analyse language techniques:
 - Imagery (blood, darkness).
 - Repetition.
 - Metaphor.
 - Discuss character development across the play.
 - Explain how themes evolve.
-

8. ONE-PARAGRAPH OVERVIEW (For Quick Recall)

Macbeth is a tragedy about a brave soldier whose ambition, fuelled by prophecy and persuasion, leads him to murder his king and seize the throne. Consumed by guilt and paranoia, he commits further crimes to protect his power. Ultimately, natural order is restored when he is defeated and justice prevails.